(Senator William Fulbright, Chairman of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee)

The nuclear history of the Cold War needs to be understood through various complex interactions, including those of ideology, technology, and politics. Yet the ideas and actions of individual political leaders are essential. This may be true of all political history, but with nuclear weapons it is of preeminent importance. As John F. Kennedy remarked to his press secretary, Pierre Salinger: 'Do you realize that if I make a mistake in this crisis 200 million people are going to get killed.'[5] Khrushchev was in a different political position, inasmuch as policy in Moscow was made by the Presidium not just the Soviet Premier. But in the early 1960s the fate of the earth rested in the hands of a few men (there being no women in relevant command positions).

Fidel Castro did not have a finger on a nuclear trigger, although at times US officials worried that he might, and it now appears that Moscow intended the transfer of tactical nuclear missiles to Cuba. Castro later said he would have wanted to use nuclear weapons against a US invasion, and at the height of the crisis he sent Khrushchev a letter that seemingly advocated a Soviet nuclear attack on the United States, if Washington attacked Cuba. These issues are discussed in chapter seven.

There could not have been a Cuban missile crisis without the Cuban revolution. That revolution would not have happened without Fidel Castro. The 'Maximum Leader' remains an iconic figure of the twentieth century. And in recent years, attention on his role, and that of his country, has been re-invigorated. In their 2018 book, *Dark Beyond Darkness*, James Blight and janet Lang argue that the central role of Cuba in the crisis has been neglected, and this has contributed to an underestimation of the risk of nuclear war. They contend that Cuba is treated as 'little more than a jungle-covered parking lot for Russian missiles,' while 'Havana [has] a non-speaking, walk-on role in the drama.'[6] Blight and Lang's assessments echo previous studies that focus not just on thirteen days in October 1962, but from Eisenhower's authorisation of CIA plans for regime change in Havana